



From Erving to Goffman

A Work in Performance?

Yves Winkin

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Goffman in the Open Series

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translated by

*Yves Winkin &
Wendy Leeds-Hurwitz*

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PART ONE

Such a Short Life, Such a Powerful Body of Work

Erving Manual Goffman was born in Mannville, Alberta, Canada, on June 11, 1922. His parents were Jewish immigrants from Ukraine (Russia at the time). His father, Max Goffman, tried to establish his clothing business in several small towns before settling, in 1926, in Dauphin, Manitoba, 250 kilometers northwest of Winnipeg. His mother, Ann Averbach, stayed at home with the two children. Frances, born in 1919, remained the older sister who looked after the younger brother. Dauphin had a population of four thousand, and in just a few years became a “wheat and rail” town: Wheat was brought to the vicinity of the train station, stored in silos, and then loaded onto long trains that transported it across Canada. This was the city’s source of wealth, and it weathered the Great Depression with seemingly little trouble (Little, 1988, pp. 186–187). A large Ukrainian community had developed by the turn of the century, and relations with the tiny Jewish community were neutral to cordial. Max Goffman’s ready-to-wear business was doing well, so much so that he bought a second store, named “The Model Shoppe,” in the early thirties. He sold it a few years later to buy a beautiful house in Winnipeg’s North End, where he moved his family in 1937, while commuting weekly himself. Max was a quiet, pipe-and-cigar-smoking man who loved to play cards and had a strong business sense.¹ He would buy

¹ Interview on June 1, 1991, with his daughter Frances and his son-in-law, Charles (Chuck)

clothing in bulk in Montreal to sell at retail prices in Dauphin, publicizing his role as middleman in the *Dauphin Herald and Press* with articles² and spectacular advertising inserts.³

Moving to beautiful, tree-lined Scotia Street in Winnipeg represented an important social and symbolic step forward for the Goffman family. Not only did they leave a small Canadian prairie town to become part of a large city with 250,000 residents, but Winnipeg was becoming one of English-speaking Canada's great cities in every respect. In addition, by moving they joined a Jewish community of seventeen thousand households,⁴ most of them in the North End, a densely populated neighborhood that was virtually a city within the city, having its own stores, schools, and synagogues (Gutkin & Gutkin, 1987). And, above all, they lived on the right side of Machray Avenue: They could not be confused with first-generation Jewish immigrants (although that is exactly what they were); they lived surrounded by wealthy Jewish families, who were spatially and culturally close to families of English descent.⁵

It was only natural that Erving should enter St. John's Technical High School, a top-tier state school run by an alumnus of Oxford's progressive Ruskin College. He even found his way into the group of "competitive sharks," as one of his fellow students, Jack Ludwig, put it in *Requiem for Bibul*, a partly autobiographical short story (Gutkin & Gutkin, 1987, p. 242). No longer called "Goofy" as he was at Dauphin Junior High,⁶ "Goff" was brilliant, but different from the others: He did not invite guests to his house; he loved Wagner; he conducted chemistry experiments in his cellar; he did not care about politics or practice any religion. But he was very good on the parallel bars.⁷ In the 1939 yearbook, he was not very visible in the group photo, as

Bay.

² "Max Goffman left on his annual buying trip to Montreal Tuesday," reported "The Local Round," in an early February 1932 edition of *The Dauphin Herald and Press*.

³ "You've never seen such a diversity of stunning hat styles. All designed to lend you the sort of individuality you admire in stunningly groomed women." Consider that his son would later write a book entitled *Gender Advertisements*.

⁴ *Canadian Jewish Yearbook*, 1939.

⁵ "Eastward from Main to the Red River, the well-to-do Jews lived in style, gradually encroaching on the 'English,' who occupied the leafy, elegant Scotia Street running along the river to Kildonan Park" (Gutkin, 1980, p. 145).

⁶ Interview with Hugh Fox, Goffman's classmate at Dauphin Junior High School, May 29, 1991.

⁷ Interviews with two of his fellow students, Meyer Brownstone (March 30, 1993) and Brian Burke (May 30, 1991).

if he were already trying to go incognito. A pattern of his public behavior was becoming established.

Early in the fall of 1939, Goffman enrolled at the University of Manitoba in Winnipeg. Like most of his fellow students, he could have stayed at St. John's Tech for a "twelfth year" and thus entered directly into the university's second year, avoiding tuition fees. Instead, he set off on his own after his "eleventh year" and, without scholarships or assistance of any kind, began a bachelor's degree in the sciences: essentially courses in mathematics, physics, and chemistry.⁸ On the surface, the war that was already shaking Europe was still far away, and Canada continued to move at its own pace. But something must have been going on in Erving's life. In 1942, his sister Frances, with whom he remained close, was unable to contact him.⁹ That time remains a black hole. Did he finish his studies in physics and chemistry? Probably not. Did he enlist in the Canadian army (university students were exempt from military service)? Was he discharged? Probably not. In any case, he reappeared in the summer of 1943 at the National Film Board (NFB) in Ottawa, which became the home of many young Canadian intellectuals during the war. The NFB produced hundreds of documentaries and morale-boosting films for the Allied troops. Erving did not make any films, but the experience imbued him with an aptitude for visual culture that he would go on to cultivate throughout his life, as evidenced by *Frame Analysis* (1974) and his analysis of advertising photographs in *Gender Advertisements* (1979).

One of his NFB friends, Dennis Wrong, suggested that Erving complete his undergraduate degree at the University of Toronto, enrolling with him in various sociology and anthropology courses.¹⁰ In this way, Erving would experience three significant initiations. The first was with a somewhat strange anthropologist, C. W. M. Hart, who had been trained by the mythical Reginald Radcliffe-Brown. Hart lectured in a formal academic gown, pacing up and down the amphitheater stairs.¹¹ It was thanks to him that Goffman studied Durkheim's *Le Suicide* over the year. The second was with a twenty-six-year-old anthropologist from Chicago, who had no equal when it came to showing how a young bourgeois woman should hold her cigarette or how one should smile in the South (by curling the lower lip). This was Ray Birdwhistell, the only teacher who dared to take his students

⁸ Information supplied on June 13, 1983, by the archivist at the University of Manitoba to Greg Smith, who kindly forwarded it to me.

⁹ Interview with Frances Bay-Goffman, June 1, 1991.

¹⁰ Interview with Dennis Wrong, September 1, 1986.

¹¹ Interview with Ray Birdwhistell, May 14, 1985.

outside the confines of the university to observe the relationship between clothing, gestures, and social class, from the perspective of anthropologist Lloyd Warner, who had been his thesis supervisor. Goffman would later say how formative the young anthropologist's perspective had been for him.¹² The third initiation was even more direct: It was offered by his girlfriend, Elizabeth (Liz) Bott, whose parents were both professors at the University of Toronto. She took him to quite a few chic parties; he made her read Freud. They went to the University of Chicago together, she in anthropology, he in sociology. They broke up in 1946 but remained very close all their lives.¹³

It was not so much the courses he took over the next four years that strengthened the young Goffman's intellectual disposition, even though his teachers were among the best-known in American sociology at the time (Herbert Blumer, Louis Wirth, Everett Hughes, Lloyd Warner). Rather, it was the endless discussions with his fellow students and the countless books he devoured, from detective novels and treatises on the epistemology of science to literary works by Marcel Proust and Elizabeth Bowen.

His closest friends in Chicago were often older students with real-life experience, far removed from the academic world. Ned Polsky was a professional pool player. Howard Becker played piano in nightclubs. Fred Davis drove a cab. Bob Habenstein sold brushes door-to-door to feed his small family.¹⁴ Most served in the war and had scholarships as veterans. They knew that Erving could be difficult, and that you had to be on your guard with him: Some of them called him "little dagger."¹⁵

In 1948, Bott introduced him to one of her master's students in human development: Angelica Schuyler Choate, nicknamed "Sky." Erving liked her and found her calming. Did he know that she was a Boston brahmin? Her family tree could serve as a guide to American history. On her maternal grandmother's side, there was John Pierpont Morgan, Jr. Her maternal grandfather's cousin was Walter Van Rensselaer Berry, a lawyer who lived in Paris and cultivated friendships with Marcel Proust and Paul Valéry, among others. Her mother's brother was Harry Crosby, who lived in Paris in style with his wife Caresse—before committing suicide with his mistress in New York in 1929. A year before his death, he and Caresse founded the Black Sun Press, which published several famous authors in the 1930s through

¹² Interview with Erving Goffman, April 23, 1980.

¹³ Interview with Liz Bott, October 10, 1987.

¹⁴ Letter from Bob Habenstein to YW, January 27, 1998.

¹⁵ Interview with Joe Gusfield, April 21, 1987.

the 1950s (e.g., Joyce, Lawrence, Hemingway). How could Erving fit in with this history? How best to interact with Sky's parents? By objectifying them. Specifically, he developed the concept of "class status symbol," which was the subject of his first paper in 1949 and his first publication in 1951. "In many societies, avocational pursuits involving the cultivation of arts, 'tastes,' sports, and handicrafts have been used as symbols of class status. . . . The style and manner of a class are . . . psychologically ill-suited to those whose life experiences took place in another class" (Goffman, 1951, p. 300). Erving certainly speaks here from his own experience. In fact, he thanks Sky in a footnote on the first page. From his very first public lecture, we can see how Erving integrated elements of his private life into an apparently impersonal discourse. No trace of his oral performance has survived; only the reworked text has been published. But we can see in it the first manifestations of the conversion of Erving's life into Goffman's work.

In 1949, Goffman reached two important milestones. The first was the submission of his master's thesis, written under the supervision of Lloyd Warner. To understand its somewhat mysterious title, "Some Characteristics of Response to Depicted Experience," it is necessary to explain that Warner, working at the time with William Henry, a psychologist specializing in projective tests, wanted Goffman to take up their study of the relationship between socio-economic status and the personality of radio listeners (Goffman, 1949, p. 69). It may seem strange today, but during those years, the social sciences, especially in the US, had adopted the investigative tools of psychologists to pinpoint audiences, their expectations, their interests, etc. This explains why Goffman administered the TAT (Thematic Apperception Test: a series of hazy images from which the subject must invent a story) to fifty women from Chicago's urban bourgeoisie. However, he soon realized the theoretical and methodological weaknesses of the TAT. From then on, his thesis was not only a severe critique of the TAT as a social science tool, but also an ethnographic rendering of the interview situations, enabling him to recontextualize the answers provided—and to salvage his work. In the final pages, we discover sentences like this one, aptly describing a "bohemian bourgeois" atmosphere: "In many living rooms the ritual of order and cleanliness was nicely violated by the permitted presence of a dog, a child, a huge toy, or fireplace-basket of coal or wood" (1949, p. 69). Goffman's style is already apparent, including his production of unexpected associations (e.g., "nicely violated"). We can also detect his interest in bourgeois life, as embodied by Sky and her family.

The second 1949 milestone was his departure for Edinburgh in October. Warner had suggested his name to an old acquaintance, Ralph Piddington, who was opening an anthropology department at the University of Edinburgh. Why did Erving accept this offer? It was probably not designed as an escape from Sky, nor for the pleasure of supervising students, nor to baby-sit for his colleague Tom Burns,¹⁶ but rather for the opportunity to work in an island society, just as the great historical anthropologists had done, starting with Radcliffe-Brown. Indeed, as early as December, Erving went to Baltasound, the main community on Unst, the most northerly of the Shetland Islands. In winter, the sun appears around 10 a.m. and disappears around 3:30 p.m. From the start to the end of the year, the 120-kilometer island is battered by winds, sometimes accompanied by brief but violent rainfall. Approximately one thousand inhabitants lived there at the time. Most were farmers (“The average crofter has few score sheep, a few ponies and cows, and a few acres of arable land,” Goffman, 1952, p. 3). A second group worked in the service industry, and a third constituted the gentry who owned the land. Between December 1949 and May 1951, Erving spent twelve months in the field. For the first two months, he took up residence at the island’s only hotel, where two young maids became his informants. The staff called him *peerie* Goffman (“little Goffman”) amongst themselves (Winkin, 2000). In early 1950, he bought a small bungalow behind the hotel but continued to take his meals with the two maids and the cook (Winkin, 2000). In the summer of 1950, he took a job as a dishwasher at the hotel, thus strengthening his ties with the staff, as well as with a few regular guests, such as the minister, the doctor, and the doctor’s wife. In addition, he made the rounds with the letter carrier, played billiards with the youngsters, and attended weddings and funerals. He took photographs with his Leica. But his aim was not to make a study of the community in the manner of Warner. Rather it was a study in a community, as explained at the beginning of his thesis. He wanted to “study the rules of conduct which islanders adhered to as they engaged in social interaction with one another” (1952, p. 3). In a way, he envisioned the island as a giant laboratory, where natural experiments in “communication conduct” could take place.

Between the end of his contract as an “instructor” at Edinburgh University in the autumn of 1951 and his return to Chicago in the spring of 1952, there was a gap of several months. Where did he go? Probably to Paris with Sky,

¹⁶ Interview with Tom Burns, July 8, 1986. Eminent sociologist of organizations, Burns dedicated an entire book to Goffman’s work (Burns, 1992).

in the rue de Lille apartment kept by Aunt Caresse, Harry Crosby's widow. There he would begin writing his thesis; it seems unlikely that he was drawn into the existentialist cafés and jazz clubs of Saint-Germain-des-Prés. He would later tell a colleague that there is no better place than Paris to write a thesis, but we do not know more.¹⁷

Returning to Chicago, Erving found the atmosphere of the Sociology Department dramatically changed. Louis Wirth had died of a heart attack; William Ogburn and Ellsworth Faris had announced their retirement; Herbert Blumer had left for Berkeley; Lloyd Warner was involved in Social Research, Inc., the consulting firm he had founded with a few former students; Everett Hughes was brooding in his corner. After a brief period of despondency, Erving bounced back: He submitted his final PhD thesis statement in May, married Sky¹⁸ in July, and published "Cooling the Mark Out" in the prestigious journal *Psychiatry* in November (Goffman, 1952). In addition, he landed two contracts. One was with Edward Shils, the redoubtable professor of sociology and political philosophy, who let him do what he wanted, while thinking no less of him.¹⁹ The other was with the benevolent Warner, who took him on board as part of his consultancy firm to study service stations around Chicago on behalf of the American Petroleum Institute (Smith & Winkin, 2012). The result was a report in February 1953, *The Service Station Dealer: The Man and his Work*, which does not list Goffman's name, but does include his sparkling style.

Two births marked 1953 for Erving: that of his son Tom, born in April, and that of his thesis, defended in early summer. Goffman would later say that his thesis was not well-received. The jury, made up of Warner, Anselm Strauss, and Donald Horton,²⁰ was taken aback. Firstly, by the title: "Communication Conduct in an Island Community." Nobody was talking about "communication" at the time, except Bernard Berelson and Douglas Waples, two professors of library sciences who had just founded the interdisciplinary Committee on Communication at the University of Chicago (Wahl-Jorgensen, 2004). Goffman also invented new vocabulary: "safe supplies," "faulty per-

¹⁷ Interview with Dean MacCannell, May 17, 1987.

¹⁸ I've never been able to learn whether it was a "grand wedding" or a "hush hush" wedding. Tom Goffman was born on April 16, 1953, ten months after the wedding, which clears up one red herring.

¹⁹ Interview with Edward Shils, September 17, 1988.

²⁰ Donald Horton was then a young professor, recently arrived in Chicago. He probably replaced Everett Hughes on Goffman's jury. Hughes worked at Frankfurt University between March and June 1953, before traveling around Europe during the summer, notably to Paris and Liège (email from Philippe Vienne, December 19, 2020).

son,” and so on. All of these terms make sense, but some seem to disappear after a few pages, to be replaced by still more new terms. Last but not least, Goffman had overturned the expectations of a department accustomed to fieldwork theses. True, he remained faithful to the ethnographic approach at the heart of the “Chicago School,” but he dared to reverse priorities: The descriptive vignettes are clearly secondary to the general propositions. Warner was expecting a “community study” in the style of Solon Kimball and Conrad Arensberg, whom he had sent to Ireland in the 1930s. In fact, as early as 1953, Goffman had laid the foundations for his entire body of work. His thesis was wildly ambitious, a fact that his jury neither understood nor admitted, grudgingly granting him the title of doctor.

In early 1954, sociologist John Clausen, working for the National Institute of Mental Health (NIMH), came to interview Erving for a position in the new Laboratory of Socio-Environmental Studies he was creating. NIMH officials were then concerned about the increase in the number of patients undergoing psychiatric treatment and the corresponding growth in the number of hospitals dedicated to them: up to ten thousand beds in some cities. The medical sciences were at a loss and wanted to know whether the social sciences might have a solution to offer. It was David Riesman, then professor of social sciences at the University of Chicago, who suggested Goffman’s name to Clausen: “He’s the most perceptive young man I’ve ever met in my life.”²¹ But what Clausen had not anticipated was that Goffman would turn the tables and ask his own questions. Apparently satisfied with Clausen’s answers, he agreed to bring his wife and child to Washington, DC, but on condition that he would have complete freedom in his choice of hospital, without having to consider psychiatric definitions of mental illness.²² Clausen was stunned by such assurance, if not arrogance, but hired Goffman anyway.

In early 1954, Goffman devoted a great deal of time to preparing a manuscript, provisionally entitled “Impression Management in Social Establishments”: a forerunner of *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*. He circulated the draft to a few close colleagues: Robert Habenstein, Warren Peterson, and Harold Garfinkel.²³ Peterson was enthusiastic:

²¹ Interview with John Clausen, May 4, 1987.

²² Letter from John Clausen to YW, September 2, 1992.

²³ Pages from this manuscript are held in the Garfinkel Archives at the University of California, Los Angeles, library. I would like to thank Gary Jaworski for putting me on the trail of this document and Wendy Leeds-Hurwitz for giving me access to it.

This, I think, is truly great. It should rank you among the giants, and if that isn't recognized for a year or two, don't worry about it. . . . It should get into the textbooks within ten years, remain there for thirty or forty, at which time someone will decide that Goffman is out of date and you will be mentioned in histories of sociology.²⁴

In the fall, Erving, Sky, and Tom moved to the Washington, DC, suburb of Bethesda. Erving began by working in two pavilions at the NIMH Medical Center. Ward A was dedicated to pharmacological research; patients there were in full possession of their faculties. Erving lived among them for two months as a "control subject." Ward B was reserved for patients declared to be schizophrenic. Erving spent a few days a week there as the team's sociologist. In June 1955 he wrote of this experience in "Notes on Deference and Decorum in a Hospital Setting," published a year later in *The American Anthropologist* under the title "The Nature of Deference and Demeanor."²⁵ However, the 1956 version no longer includes the pretty gloomy description found in 1955:

Mental hospitals throughout the world segregate their patients according to "degree of illness." By and large this means that patients are graded according to the degree to which they violate ceremonial rules of social intercourse. . . . In this institutionalization of a black mass it is no wonder that hospital staff can often be recruited for acolytes. (p. 45)

It was in this frame of mind that Erving entered St. Elizabeths Psychiatric Hospital in 1955 for a year of participant observation. As he made clear in the preface to *Asylums*, the book he published in 1961 based on his experience at the hospital, he "came to the hospital with no great respect for the discipline of psychiatry nor for agencies content with its current practice" (p. x). Located in Anacostia, on the southeastern outskirts of Washington, DC, St. Elizabeths is one of the oldest psychiatric hospitals in the United States. It is made up of a multitude of pavilions set in an immense wooded park with a bird's-eye view of downtown Washington, DC (Winkin, 2022c). At the time Erving entered, it had seven thousand beds. It was a quasi-autarkic institution, with a bakery and a small train to transport goods.

²⁴ Unpublished memorandum from William Peterson to Erving Goffman, February 2, 1954.

²⁵ This text was then reprinted in *Interaction Ritual*, published in 1967.

Fundamentally, Erving wanted to understand the hospital from the inside, from the patients' point of view, not that of the psychiatrists. He needed to find a role that would be accepted by both staff and patients: To that end, he became "assistant to the athletic director," with no white jacket and no set of keys, just a T-shirt, jeans, sneakers—and a basketball. That was how he found himself playing tennis with the poet Ezra Pound, who was locked up in St. Elizabeths for several years after expressing sympathy for Mussolini's fascism (and being declared insane for it). All Erving had to do was abandon his sneakers in the corner to look like a patient.²⁶ He was not supposed to spend the night in the hospital. However, he made friends with the security guards at the entrance, who signed the register for him.

As he sank deeper and deeper into the hospital's "clandestine life," his anger mounted. He was not always able to control it completely. For example, at a seminar in his laboratory, he wanted to show how the staff physically controlled patients without leaving any trace of a blow. He grabbed one of his colleagues, someone much bigger than he, and twisted his tie, forcing his head to the table. Panicked, his colleagues asked him to stop immediately.²⁷ Another example: When invited to the Macy Conferences at Princeton in October 1956, he gave a very aggressive speech against psychiatry, despite or possibly because of the fact that there were many psychiatrists in the audience. Led by anthropologist Margaret Mead, they hit back blow for blow. He eventually made amends, but only rhetorically. I will return to this episode later,²⁸ but I see it as a tipping point: Erving is becoming Goffman, up against older peers who are more established than he, so we will have to stop calling him by his first name too often.

At home, the mood was no better. Sky was alone with Tom most of the time. Erving locked himself in his office, working like a madman. His rate of publication was dizzying: "On Face-Work" in 1955, "The Nature of Deference and Demeanor" and "Embarrassment and Social Organization" in 1956. Also in 1956, he published the first version of *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life* with the Social Science Research Centre at the University of Edinburgh. In the acknowledgements, he wrote: "Without the collaboration of my wife, Angelica S. Goffman, this report would not have been written." Indeed, she was his first reader, typist, and editor. But the happy days of student life in Chicago seemed long gone. Erving wanted a settled life, as if haunted by the

²⁶ Letter from John Clausen to YW, September 2, 1992.

²⁷ Interview with Erwin Linn, one of Goffman's colleagues at NIMH, December 6, 1995.

²⁸ See part 2, p. 21.

model of his in-laws, whom he barely knew. No more posters on the walls, no more framed reproductions, but real paintings instead. Sky borrowed a Raoul Dufy from her mother to please him. But such demands weighed heavily on her, and she did not always know how to cope.²⁹

A respite came in 1957. Blumer, who had left Chicago to head the new sociology department at the University of California at Berkeley, invited Goffman to join him. Goffman accepted. At the time, Berkeley was doing well: Student enrollment was increasing, and professors were young and rapidly promoted. Interdisciplinary groups were formed on the basis of mutual esteem. Every Saturday morning, for example, an informal seminar was held on the theme of “language and society” (Murray, 1998). Participants included anthropologists (Dell Hymes, Ethel Albert), linguists (John Gumperz, Susan Ervin-Tripp), a psychologist (Dan Slobin), a philosopher (John Searle) and two sociologists: Aaron Cicourel and Erving Goffman, who took up his post in January 1958. He settled alone in Berkeley. Sky and Tom joined him a year later, once Erving had time to earn tenure.

In this intellectually stimulating atmosphere, Goffman published five books in five years: the definitive version of *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life* (1959), *Encounters* (1961b), *Asylums* (1961a), *Behavior in Public Places* (1963a), and *Stigma* (1963b). Not surprisingly, he was awarded tenure in 1960 and reached the rank of professor in 1962. In 1961, he received the McIver Award from the American Sociological Association. His career was taking off. He was on the road to fame, thanks to *Presentation of Self*, which was published directly in paperback by Anchor Books and went on to sell hundreds of thousands of copies, benefiting in part from the wave of baby boomers now of university age.

At home, however, life was not easy. Sky experienced episodes of deep depression. Hospitalization was out of the question, as Erving knew the situation too well. So, he made sure to keep the key to the medicine cabinet in his possession. When Sky’s health permitted, they drove—Erving had bought himself a Morgan—to Las Vegas, Reno, or Lake Tahoe for casino weekends. They enjoyed playing blackjack, using strategy based on the early mathematical models developed by Edward Thorp. This strategy makes it possible to “beat the dealer” by betting the same amount until the game tips over. This required coming to the table with a fair amount of money—but that was not a problem for Sky, who also had an excellent visual memory.

²⁹ Information provided in an exchange of letters with Helen and Stewart Perry in 1992. The Perrys were close friends of Angelica Choate. Helen was the secretary for *Psychiatry* and Stewart ran one of the NIMH clinics.

Erving was not very good because he could not keep a poker face. But they still managed to win a fair number of games—which eventually led to them being placed on the unwanted list at several establishments. When they were asked to leave the premises, they were delighted to do so because it meant they were considered too good.³⁰

This world of play, which allowed him to reconnect with Sky from time to time, also inspired Erving's third great piece of fieldwork, the most mysterious, about which he published almost nothing. He alluded to it a few times in "Where the Action Is," the sixth chapter of *Interaction Ritual*. But nothing else. Even so, he prepared for the context very seriously, taking croupier training courses, and buying special pants with very deep pockets so as to always have chips on hand.³¹ A journalist named Paul Jacobs apparently interceded on his behalf with Moe Dalitz, one of the Jewish Mafia bosses who controlled several casinos at the time. Jacobs reportedly told Goffman: "I have got you a position. But you better not write anything about Dalitz—or his casinos. The man has a lot of muscle in this town. He's head of the *schul*."³² If Dalitz played the role of Goffman's protector, he must have worked at either the Desert Inn or the Stardust, two bastions of the Jewish Connection. He sometimes stayed in Las Vegas for several weeks, renting a studio with his son, whom he no longer dared leave with his mother for too long, given her deteriorating mental health.

Sky committed suicide in May 1964. Erving was totally devastated, although he did not let it show to visitors. Another way of keeping control was to write "The Insanity of Place," a third-person account of their last years together. This was Goffman's only autobiographical article, and the most moving, once you know who he was describing (1973, pp. 313–361).

That same year, 1964, Berkeley became the epicenter of the student revolt: student strikes, arrests, and the National Guard on campus. Goffman had little sympathy for the movement and showed little patience with his students. Remaining cloistered at home, he told one of his doctoral students "the university is a place to pick up your mail" (quoted in G. Marx, 1984, p. 659). Thus it came as no surprise when he left Berkeley in 1966. He was a visiting professor at the University of Manchester for a few weeks in the spring, then moved with his son to Cambridge, Massachusetts, where he spent a year as a research fellow at Harvard's Center for International Af-

³⁰ Interview with Tom Goffman, August 24, 1991.

³¹ Interview with Aaron Cicourel, April 18, 1985. Cicourel visited Goffman during one of his stays in Las Vegas.

³² Letter from Ted Harwood to YW, December 30, 1991. "Schul" in Yiddish means "school."

fairs. The Center was founded in 1958 by two professors, Robert Bowie and Henry Kissinger. Kissinger, in his capacity as advisor to the US government, was certainly busy with other pressing matters in the autumn of 1966, but Goffman forged a working relationship with Thomas Schelling, the future Nobel Prize winner in Economics in 2005, whose work on strategic issues was to influence Goffman's thinking. Despite the mentorship he received there, strolling around the center was out of the question for Goffman, who mainly opted to work at home, escaping only from time to time, sometimes to dine with a few colleagues at Harvard's Faculty Club,³³ sometimes for an outing to Boston.³⁴ As a result, his year at Cambridge proved very productive: He published *Interaction Ritual* in 1967, wrote the manuscript for *Strategic Interaction*, which came out in 1969, and worked on *Frame Analysis*.

Goffman and Tom returned to Berkeley in 1967–1968, but he had to decide whether to stay or accept one of the offers made by various universities. The conditions offered by the University of Pennsylvania were particularly generous. As Benjamin Franklin Professor, he would only have to teach one seminar a year, and his salary would rise from \$20,000 to \$30,000,³⁵ so he moved to Philadelphia at the end of 1968. His office (and that of his private secretary) was located in the Anthropology Department, not the Sociology Department, to avoid any tension. The years at Penn were to be very serene. He bought and had renovated a beautiful house on Rittenhouse Square, in one of the city's most upscale neighborhoods. He protected himself by working and welcoming students into his home and having almost no presence on campus; it was rumored that his secretary met him on the sidewalk to deliver his mail. But this did not stop him from getting involved in several collective activities at the University of Pennsylvania, often in partnership with Dell Hymes, whom he had known since Berkeley: He was associate editor of the journal *Language in Society*, created and directed by Hymes, and together they edited the Communication and Conduct series launched by the University of Pennsylvania Press. They also joined forces with anthropologist and musicologist John Szwed to create the Center for Urban

³³ Colleagues included John Rawls, Robert Nozick, and Charles Fried (letter from Thomas Schelling to YW, April 30, 1991).

³⁴ This is how he met documentary filmmaker Frederick Wiseman, who was editing *Titicut Follies*. They didn't hit it off (interview with Wiseman, November 21, 2002). See Ricks (2010, p. 57).

³⁵ Translated into 2026 dollars, \$20,000 dollars in 1968 would be \$186,000, and \$30,000 would be \$279,000. A salary analysis from *The Chronicle of Higher Education* shows that the University of Pennsylvania paid its full professors an average annual salary of \$223,000 in 2021–2022.

Ethnography, offering fellowships to doctoral students wishing to conduct ethnographic work in urban environments. He was undoubtedly caught up in the flood of creative energy that swept through the university in the 1970s. A new generation of professors in their thirties and forties arrived on campus; they attracted one other, created interdisciplinary alliances, and shared both students and invitations (Leeds-Hurwitz & Sigman, 2010). Hymes brought Goffman, and together they brought William Labov; then Goffman brought Birdwhistell, and so on (Leeds-Hurwitz, 2025).

Students were encouraged to take courses outside their own department, and to attend lectures by visiting foreign professors. Evenings often brought teachers and students together, though Goffman was not known to participate in these events; he seemed to be keeping his distance. His son was about to enter medicine. Goffman accepted invitations to travel abroad: Paris, Urbino, Rio de Janeiro, etc., and he often received colleagues in his home. In 1972, for example, he hosted Pierre Bourdieu while the latter was visiting the Princeton Institute for Advanced Study.³⁶ He enjoyed unearthing antiques with Henry Glassie, a good colleague in the Folklore department. To sneak into sales reserved for professionals, they printed a business card: "*Goffman & Glassie—English Oak. Folk Art.*"³⁷ Another hobby was unicycling, which Goffman practiced through the quiet streets of his neighborhood. Predictably, he fell and broke a leg. The story (as told by Gillian Sankoff) does not say whether he was listening on his walkman to Randy Newman's "Short People," one of his favorite songs. In 1977, he won a Guggenheim Fellowship to study casinos, not only in New Jersey, which had just authorized them, but elsewhere in the world.³⁸ At the same time, he met Gillian Sankoff, a Canadian sociolinguist who had come to Penn to work with Labov. She began by taking Goffman's seminar and ended up accompanying him to the American Sociological Association's conferences.³⁹ They married in 1981.

³⁶ Bourdieu had already had *Asylums* translated in the "Le Sens commun" collection he edited at Editions de Minuit; in the 1970s and 1980s, he translated no fewer than seven books by Goffman, making Goffman the most translated contemporary American sociologist in France. See Winkin (2023).

³⁷ This business card was given to me by Henry Glassie when we met on April 18, 1986.

³⁸ According to Lee Ann Draud, Goffman's secretary and editorial assistant at the University of Pennsylvania, Goffman rented an apartment in Nevada for nine months, in order to resume fieldwork in the state's casinos (interview with YW, April 29, 1991). It is unclear whether he stayed there that long, but in any case, he did not teach any courses in Philadelphia in 1977–1978.

³⁹ In August 1980, Goffman introduced Gillian as his "lifemate" to Mary Jo Deegan, then a young assistant professor at the University of Nebraska (Deegan, 2014, p. 77).

The years at Penn were especially productive: *Strategic Interaction* (1969), *Relations in Public* (1971), *Frame Analysis* (1974), *Gender Advertisements* (1979), and *Forms of Talk* (1981). The year 1982 should have been his year of triumph: He became father to little Alice; he spent May in Paris with Gillian at Bourdieu's invitation; he was elected thirty-seventh president of the American Sociological Association. But, early in the summer, his health took a sudden turn for the worse: He was diagnosed with cancer. He had to cancel his presidential address, the title of which, "The Interaction Order," was also the title of the last chapter of his doctoral thesis, as if he had come full circle. He died in Philadelphia on November 20, 1982.